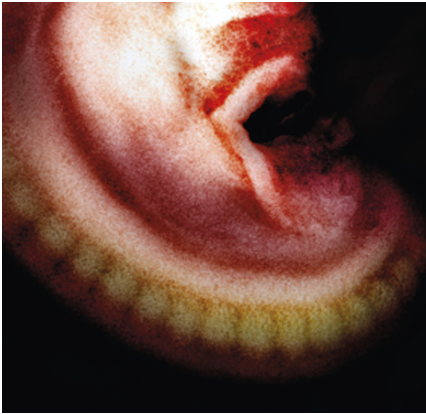




YOU ARE **6 WEEKS AND 1 DAY**

237 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

In this side view of the embryo the spinal cord is clearly curved as it begins to develop. The pale-yellow ridgelike structures along the back are somites—your baby’s developing muscular system.

“You may be spending a lot of time in front of the mirror trying to spot your “bump,” but it could be weeks yet before you show.”

Like most newly pregnant women, you’re probably on the lookout for a rounded belly, but it’s unlikely to make an appearance just yet. On average, the fourth month marks the greatest period of growth, with your pregnancy most definitely appearing as a rounded abdomen.

If it’s not your first pregnancy, you might show earlier, possibly as early as eight to 10 weeks, since your abdominal muscles will be more relaxed. Conversely, women who have firm abdominal muscles may show later. If you are expecting twins or triplets, you can expect to show even earlier.

STRENGTHEN YOUR ABDOMINALS

Toward the end of the first trimester, or when you start “showing”, you should stop doing [abdominal exercises](#) on your back. When you are doing abdominal exercises, it’s important to breathe correctly—inhale to start and exhale on each effort.

The purpose of abdominal exercises is to strengthen core muscles. The deeper transverse abdominis muscle that runs horizontally across your body is vital for core stability and strength as your baby develops. The rectus abdominis muscle that runs vertically down your body will stretch during pregnancy and weaken, so it’s vital to keep the transverse muscle and the back muscles strong to help your posture and support your spine.

The sooner you begin to strengthen the transverse abdominis, the better. Below is one of the exercises you can do during the first trimester to strengthen this muscle.